

just carry a basic OS on a thumb drive and plug it into any of these standardised “connecting devices.” And even this is only needed assuming you don’t have an Internet OS! And data online: why not? Free for basic use, paid for heavy use.

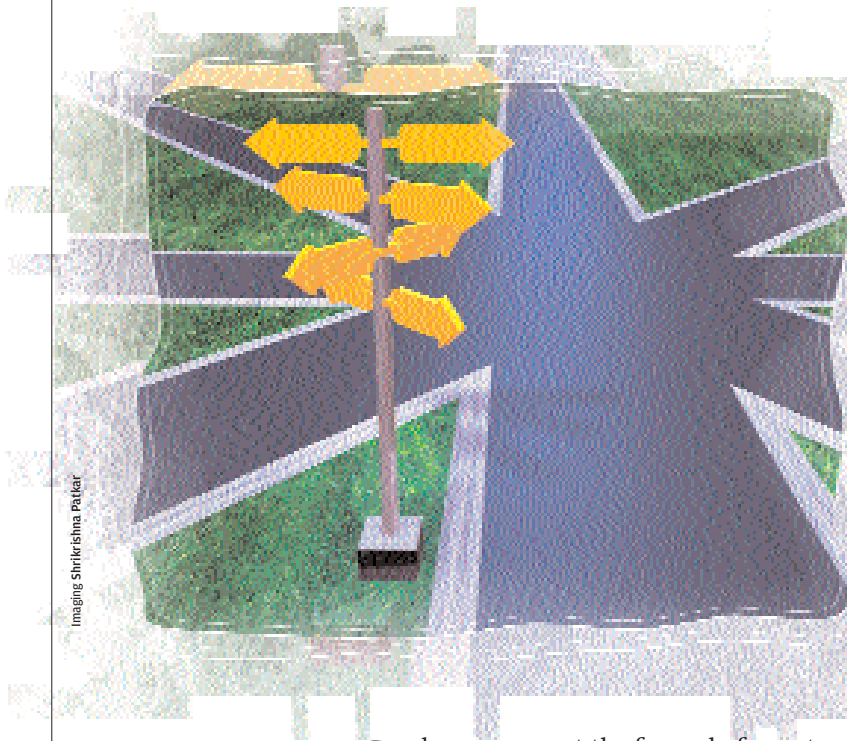
With your hard disk gone, where have your movies gone? Think YouTube. Where have your pictures gone? Think Flickr. And on, and on.

In fact, it’ll be even better, because Google’s hard disks don’t crash. They don’t have viruses either. It’s only a question of when. Google and others have already taken the baby steps. Head to <http://tinyurl.com/258km3> for more.

Sun’s “The network is the computer” comes to mind, and we now see Sun’s wisdom: they were saying this long before any of this saw the light of day. ☒

Web x.0

Don’t call a rose by any name at all!



Imaging Shrikishna Patkar

So here we are, at the fag end of our story of what the Web will be. Search, personalisation, socialising, computing, all online. A lot of what our sixth sense has told us falls under the umbrella of Web 2.0: think social networks. Some of it is still Web 1.0, as in targeted search. Some of it is, well, Web 1.4.3, as in a P2P Google.

Tell us about the future, you say. OK, the future is Web 3.0. Just kidding. Serious kidding. Fill in that “x” above with anything you like, give it a definition (complete with meme-map and all), then put it up on your blog. If you’re lucky, quite a few people will take to it. Like they’ve taken to “Web 2.0.” No, we’re not giving a dog a bad name and hanging it—we’re saying “2.0” is an unnecessary appendage, that it has no future. Allow us to be unconventional and tell you there’s going to be no Web 3.0: we’re not gazing into our crystal ball here. We’re staring into empty space for as far as we can see.

“The Emperor’s New Web,” we like to call it. Everyone’s talking about it, and no-one knows what Web 2.0 is. Yes, no-one. If crowds have wisdom, this is entirely the Emperor phenomenon—how can no-one know what it is? 68 million Google results for the term later, you’ll see no two people agreeing upon a definition. What’s worse is that all these definitions are a waste of time.

Think about a Google OS. What Web x.0 or x.3.12 would that be? Would it be a Web at all? It would be more like Sun’s The Computer... so, well, how about a Computer 1.1.0.3? Then, think about our personalised Web—where reconnaissance agents fetch you Your Page. Same question.

The sub-heads in a seminal Web 2.0-defining document—by Tim O’Reilly of O’Reilly publishing—went “The Web As Platform,” “Harnessing Collective Intelligence,” “End of the Software Release Cycle,” “Lightweight Programming Models,” “Rich User Experiences,” and more. A certain “DMBlackthorn” commented, “A lot of people on the Interweb find this Web 2.0 a bit confusing. Why can’t we just call it like it is—the Interweb?” 2.0 thumbs up for DMBlackthorn!

Now much of what O’Reilly mentioned *does* hold true for the future, such as the Web as Platform, and Harnessing Collective Intelligence. But will it hold up to 3.0, 4.0 and beyond? Stephen Baker of BusinessWeek recently said in a column that Web 3.0 will be easier, cheaper, and more pervasive; that it will be always on, everywhere; that we’ll be able to control our data better. Easier? Yes. Cheaper? Yes, if we go the Web computing way. More pervasive? Yes, if we go the Web-is-our-society way. Control our data better? Now there it goes a little fuzzy...

He invited comments upon his post, but we didn’t bother making any. These Web x.0 things are *terms*. Lots of terms. Enough already. There’s the wisdom of crowds, there’s the need for rich user experiences, and a ton of other things. Let’s take all that burden off a poor term (pun intended). ☒